The Biography of a Word: *Run*

Introduction

The English word *run* is small, old and extremely busy. In the revised *Oxford English Dictionary* (OED), the verb alone has 645 senses, the most of any English word (NPR, 2011). This essay traces the word's origin, maps how its meanings relate to each other, describes some of its multi-word units, and compares how dictionaries handle its polysemy. The semantic analysis relies mainly on Gries (2006), who coded all 815 occurrences of *to run* in the British (ICE-GB) and American (Brown) corpora.

Origin

Modern *run* merges two related Old English verbs. The first is the intransitive *rinnan/irnan*, "to run, flow, run together", which has cognates in Gothic *rinnan* and German *rinnen* "to flow" (Harper, n.d.-a). The second is the transitive *ærnan/earnan*, "ride, run to, reach", probably from Proto-Germanic **rannjanan*, the causative of a root meaning "to run" (Harper, n.d.-b). Harper (n.d.-c) notes that a link to a Proto-Indo-European root **rei-* "to run, flow" has been proposed but is doubtful, and one source lists the word as having no certain Indo-European etymology. Gries (2006, p. 76) adds that, according to etymological dictionaries, the diachronically primary senses are "fast pedestrian motion" and "to flow". So the word's history already contains both the legged-runner image and the water image, which fits the many "flowing" uses discussed below.

Meanings and Their Relations

Gries (2006) identified 56 senses and arranged them in a radial network (Figure 1 in his paper). Intransitive uses make up about 65% of all tokens (p. 68). Two ways of identifying the central sense point in different directions. A cognitive analysis that asks which sense most others can be derived from favours general "motion" (pp. 75–76). Corpus evidence instead favours "fast pedestrian motion", for four reasons:

1. It is the most frequent sense, at about 25% of tokens.
2. It is the earliest-acquired sense in child language data.
3. It is the first sense in the zero-derived noun.
4. It is the sense with the widest range of formal and semantic properties, which marks it as unmarked (pp. 75–76).

From this centre, meanings extend in several directions:

- **Non-pedestrian motion.** "Three boats that run from the mainland to the Island" (Gries, 2006, p. 64). The motion no longer needs to be fast or on foot.
- **Escape.** *Run away/off* is one of the most frequent extensions. Gries (2006, pp. 79–81) shows statistically that "escape" is distributionally closer to the prototype than to general "motion", so it attaches directly to the prototype.
- **Flow and spreading.** Tears run, colours run, and a supply "runs out" (pp. 65–66).

- **Space and time.** Tracks "run" along a course, which is extended to events lasting a period (*the play ran until one*), through the metaphor TIME IS SPACE (p. 67). *To extend spatially* has 55 tokens.
- **Abstract motion.** *Run for office*, *run into trouble* and *run through the bills* all map goals and states onto destinations and locations (pp. 66–67).
- **Causation and control.** *To cause motion* (*ran a finger down his cheek*) leads to transitive senses. The largest is *to manage* (101 tokens, 12.4% of all tokens), followed by *to execute/operate* (pp. 70–71, 85).

Gries (2006, pp. 81–83) also clusters the senses by their grammatical and semantic behaviour. The first split is between intransitive and transitive uses, and "fast pedestrian motion" and "escape" join earliest. This suggests that the way senses are distributed in real language reflects the structure linguists propose.

The mindmap that accompanies this essay groups these senses in three ways: by word class, by type of use (literal, metaphorical, metonymic), and by detailed form.

Multi-Word Units

Many meanings of *run* are carried by multi-word units rather than by the verb alone. Gries (2006, pp. 72–73) treats several as idioms because they depend on particular words and are hard to derive from other senses. They include *run the risk* (12 tokens), *run the gamut*, *run the gauntlet* and *run roughshod over*. He observes that many of them alliterate (p. 91, n. 11). Phrasal verbs are even more productive. The Oxford Learner's Dictionaries (n.d.) list a long set of *run* phrasal verbs, including *run across*, *run after*, *run away*, *run into*, *run off*, *run out*, *run over*, *run through* and *run up*. Their meanings are often figurative:

- *Run across* means "to meet with or discover by chance" (Merriam-Webster, n.d.).
- *Run out* means "to come to an end" or "to become used up" (Encyclopaedia Britannica, n.d.).
- *Run over* means "to flow over the top or edge", which is *overflow* (Encyclopaedia Britannica, n.d.).
- *Run through* covers using something up quickly, reading or practising it quickly, and occurring repeatedly throughout something (Encyclopaedia Britannica, n.d.).

Fixed noun phrases such as *in the long run* and *on the run* show the same pattern in the noun. The accompanying mindmap includes them, though Gries's own network covers the verb.

Comparing Dictionaries

The dictionaries differ sharply in how finely they divide the word. The OED's revised entry reaches 645 verb senses and runs to roughly 75 columns of print (NPR, 2011). A learner's dictionary such as the Oxford Advanced Learner's lists a much more compact set of senses, but still includes specific ones, for example the sense "to bring something into a country illegally" as in *run guns* (Oxford Learner's Dictionaries, n.d.). The Britannica Dictionary (Encyclopaedia Britannica, n.d.), which has a learner-oriented entry, puts many meanings under phrasal-verb

headings, while Merriam-Webster (n.d.) gives *run across* its own entry. In short, the same meaning may be a sub-sense in one dictionary and a separate entry in another.

Gries (2006, p. 61) argues that this reflects subjective decisions about lumping and splitting. He also found that some corpus senses, such as “to stop talking” and “to fail to understand”, were missing from corpus-based dictionaries and unfamiliar to some native speakers (p. 87). He concludes that a linguist’s intuition about which senses exist and how frequent they are is not a reliable data base on its own. A corpus-based profile is a useful complement to dictionaries, not a replacement for them.

Conclusion

The history of *run* runs from an Old English verb meaning both “to flow” and “to run”, through a prototype of fast movement on foot, to hundreds of figurative and technical uses. Corpus data support a network centred on the prototype, with branches for escape, flow, extent, control and fixed expressions. Dictionaries record this network at very different levels of detail, which is why a word like *run* is best studied with several sources side by side.

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